

PRODUCT REQUIREMENTS

Magazine Builder

Version 1 — the manual editor

Version	2.0 — supersedes v1.0 in full
Status	Approved for breakdown and build
Product	A complete manual editor. Ships and is used without any AI.
Output	Screen-first — shareable link, PDF download, page images. No commercial print output.
Later	AI generation, conversational editing, and voice follow in a subsequent release. Section 7 defines what version 1 must not preclude.
Language	English only for version 1.

This is a rebuild. An existing platform serves the same users and fails them on two counts: the interface is confusing, and its AI is unreliable. Version 1 addresses the first problem completely and defers the second rather than repeating it. A manual editor that works perfectly is a better foundation for AI than an AI layer over an editor people already struggle with.

1. Purpose and scope

We are building a tool that lets people who are not designers, and who are not confident with computers, produce magazines: community newsletters, club and church bulletins, family memory books, small-circulation publications.

Version 1 is a **complete manual editor**. Everything on the page is done by hand — clicking, dragging, resizing, typing, adding and removing photographs. It works entirely without AI, and it is a finished, shippable product on its own terms. It is not a stripped-back preview of something better.

AI generation, conversational editing, and voice interaction follow in a later release. They are out of scope here, with one exception: Section 7 sets out the constraints version 1 must respect so that the AI layer can be added later without rebuilding.

1.1 Why manual first

The AI will edit the magazine by issuing the same instructions the interface issues when a user clicks a button. That instruction layer therefore has to exist, and has to be trustworthy, before any AI is built on it. Building the editor first is not a delay to the AI work — it is the first half of it.

It also gives us something the current platform lacks: a reliable fallback. When the AI misunderstands, the user needs a way through by hand. That path has to be good.

1.2 How to read this document

Every requirement has a stable identifier such as `TXT-04`. These never change and are never reused. Use them for assigning work, writing tests, filing defects, and discussing scope.

PRIORITY	MEANING
MUST	Required for version 1. Not shippable without it.
SHOULD	Wanted for version 1. Cut if it threatens quality or the date.
LATER	Deliberately deferred. Do not build, do not scaffold for.

Each requirement carries a **Done when** line. That is the acceptance test. If it cannot be demonstrated, the requirement is not finished, however much code exists.

2. Who we are building for

2.1 Primary user

An adult, typically 70 or older, who uses a computer for email, photographs, and browsing, and has never used design software. They may have reduced fine motor control, reduced

near vision, and low confidence with unfamiliar software — they worry about breaking something and will stop rather than experiment.

They are not slow or incapable, and nothing in the product may treat them that way. They are unfamiliar with conventions designers take for granted, and unwilling to learn a large new vocabulary in order to make a newsletter.

2.2 Secondary user

A family member, volunteer, or staff member who helps with setup and is called when something goes wrong. Usually absent. The product must be usable alone.

2.3 What they make

Short publications, typically 4 to 24 pages, shared as a link or a PDF and often printed at home. Text-led with photographs. Produced on a schedule — monthly or quarterly — so the same person uses the tool repeatedly and must not relearn it each time.

2.4 The success test

PRIMARY ACCEPTANCE TEST FOR VERSION 1

A person aged 70 or over, with no design experience and no training, can create and publish a four-page magazine containing two photographs, a headline, and body text — in under 30 minutes, without asking anyone for help.

The same person can produce the following month's issue a week later without relearning the tool.

This test governs the whole of version 1. Run it with at least five real participants before the release is considered complete. If it fails, no feature list rescues the product.

3. Design principles

These are constraints, not aspirations. Where a principle conflicts with a feature, the principle wins and the feature changes.

THE CENTRAL TENSION

"Everything Canva can do" and "usable by an 80-year-old" pull in opposite directions. Canva is dense by design: small targets, controls revealed on hover, toolbars that reshape themselves by selection. That density is what makes it powerful for its audience.

Ours needs the opposite: fewer controls, larger targets, nothing hidden, and a second route to everything that normally needs a drag. **Where the two conflict, ease of use wins.** Canva already owns dense and powerful. Nobody owns genuinely easy.

1. Feedback on hover, never function

Hovering should respond — highlight the item under the pointer, change the cursor, make handles more prominent, show a tooltip. That feedback is wanted and is specified in ARR-02.

What hovering must never do is *reveal a control that is otherwise unavailable*. Our users do not sweep the pointer across the screen hunting for what appears. Touch devices have no hover at all, so anything reachable only that way is unreachable.

Allows: highlights, cursor changes, tooltips, emphasised handles, preview of the effect of a click.

Forbids: delete buttons that exist only on hover, floating toolbars that appear over an item, right-click as the only route to a function, primary functions inside a collapsed menu.

2. Drag freely — but never drag only

Dragging is the primary way to move, resize, reshape, and reorder, and it must feel immediate and precise. Nothing here restricts it.

Alongside it, every one of those operations also has a route that needs no sustained drag: arrow keys, buttons, or a typed value. Someone with a tremor or an unfamiliar trackpad gets a way through; everyone else drags as normal and never notices.

Forbids: any operation achievable *only* by dragging, including page reordering and multi-select.

3. Nothing is lost

Every action can be undone. Every destructive action is confirmed in plain words. Work saves continuously and visibly. The user must never have grounds to fear that a click will destroy their work — that fear is what stops people using a tool at all.

Forbids: unconfirmed deletion, actions outside the undo history, silent failure, manual-save-only.

4. The screen holds still

Toolbars and panels stay in the same physical position throughout. Users build memory by location, not by icon. Selecting a different kind of item changes which controls are *enabled*, never which are *present* or where they sit.

Forbids: selection-dependent toolbar layouts, panels that reorder, floating toolbars that follow the selection.

5. Plain words only

The interface uses words our users already know. No design or technical jargon appears anywhere — not in buttons, labels, tooltips, errors, or help. Section 9 fixes the approved vocabulary and it is enforced automatically.

Forbids: opacity, kerning, leading, z-index, canvas, element, object, asset, export, render, layer, crop, stroke, fill.

6. No timing, ever

Nothing requires speed. No double-clicks, no press-and-hold, no messages that vanish on their own, no session timeouts that lose work.

Forbids: auto-dismissing notifications, double-click-to-edit, long-press gestures, timed tutorials.

7. One obvious path

Each task has one recommended route, presented prominently. Alternatives may exist but never carry equal visual weight. Choice is a cost.

Forbids: three equally prominent ways to add a photo, panels with more than seven visible options, settings offered without a sensible default already chosen.

4. Global requirements

These apply to every screen and every feature. Each feature is checked against this list before it is considered complete.

GL-01 Minimum target size **MUST**

Every clickable control has a hit area of at least 44 × 44 pixels, including icon-only buttons. Adjacent controls are separated by at least 8 pixels. Selection handles are at least 14 pixels.

Done when: an automated check over the rendered interface reports zero controls below the threshold.

GL-02 Interface text size **MUST**

No interface text is smaller than 16 pixels. A setting increases all interface text to 24 pixels without breaking any layout.

Done when: every screen is inspected at both settings with no clipping, overlap, or new scrollbars.

GL-03 No hover-dependent function **MUST**

Hover feedback is required (ARR-02); hover-revealed controls are forbidden. No function is reachable only by hovering or only by right-clicking.

Done when: every function in this document is demonstrated on a touch device, where hover does not exist.

GL-04 A second route to every drag **MUST**

Moving, resizing, turning, reordering, and multi-selection are each achievable without a sustained drag — by arrow keys, buttons, or typed values. Dragging remains the primary route.

Done when: the full primary acceptance test is completed using only clicks and keyboard, with no drag at any point.

GL-05 No timed or gestural interactions **MUST**

No double-click, press-and-hold, swipe, or self-dismissing message anywhere. Messages remain until the user dismisses them.

Done when: a code audit finds no double-click or long-press handlers and no notification with a dismiss timer.

GL-06 Universal undo **MUST**

Every change to the magazine can be undone, with at least 50 steps of history. A large, permanently visible Undo button sits in a fixed position, with Redo beside it.

Done when: a script performing 50 varied actions followed by 50 undos returns the magazine to a state identical to the start.

GL-07 Confirmation before loss **MUST**

Deleting a page, deleting several items at once, or discarding changes requires confirmation stating in plain words what will be lost and what to click.

Done when: every destructive action is enumerated and each confirmation is reviewed against Section 9.

GL-08 Approved vocabulary only **MUST**

All user-facing text uses the terms in Section 9. Forbidden terms appear nowhere in the interface, help, or error messages.

Done when: an automated scan of all user-facing text against the forbidden list returns zero matches and runs in the build pipeline.

GL-09 Stable layout **MUST**

Toolbar and panels occupy the same position at all times. Selecting different item types enables and disables controls; it never moves or replaces them.

Done when: screenshots with text, a photo, and a shape selected show controls in identical positions.

GL-10 Contrast and colour independence **MUST**

All interface text meets a contrast ratio of at least 4.5:1. No information is conveyed by colour alone; colour is always paired with a label, icon, or shape.

Done when: an automated accessibility audit reports zero contrast failures and every colour-coded state carries a second signal.

GL-11 Browser zoom to 200% **MUST**

The interface remains fully functional at 200% browser zoom, with no clipping, horizontal scrolling, or overlapping panels.

Done when: the primary acceptance test is completed at 200% zoom.

GL-12 Actionable error messages **MUST**

Every error states what happened in plain words and what to do next. No error codes, no technical terms, no message that leaves the user without a next step.

Done when: every error state is catalogued with its text and reviewed against this requirement.

GL-13 Full keyboard operation **MUST**

Every function is reachable by keyboard. Focus order follows visual order. The focused control shows a visible outline of at least 3 pixels.

Done when: the primary acceptance test is completed using keyboard only.

GL-14 Screen reader support **MUST**

Every control has an accessible name describing its function in plain words. State changes are announced. Page structure uses correct landmarks and headings.

Done when: a full screen-reader pass completes the primary acceptance test.

GL-15 Panel option limit **MUST**

No panel shows more than seven options at once. Further options sit behind a labelled "More settings" control and never include anything needed for the primary acceptance test.

Done when: every panel is counted and none exceeds seven visible options by default.

GL-16 Continuous saving **MUST**

Work saves automatically to storage. A permanently visible indicator shows saved state in plain words. No user action is ever required to preserve work.

Done when: the browser is closed at ten random points during the acceptance test and nothing is lost in any case.

GL-17 Responsive interaction **MUST**

Dragging, resizing, and turning follow the pointer without perceptible lag. Typing appears immediately. Nothing the user does feels delayed.

Done when: pointer-to-screen latency stays under 16 milliseconds at the 95th percentile on a 24-page magazine.

5. Feature requirements

5.1 Magazines and pages DOC

DOC-01 Home screen MUST

On opening, the user sees their magazines as large visual previews with names and dates, plus one prominent button to start something new.

Done when: a first-time user identifies how to open an existing magazine and how to start a new one, without instruction.

DOC-02 Start from a ready-made design or blank MUST

Starting something new offers ready-made designs as large previews, plus a blank option. At least twelve designs ship at launch, covering the common uses in 2.3.

Done when: selecting any ready-made design produces a complete, correctly laid out magazine ready to edit.

DOC-03 Page size MUST

Common sizes are offered by name with real-world dimensions shown. A custom size can be entered.

Done when: each preset produces correctly proportioned pages on screen and in the downloaded PDF.

DOC-04 Add, delete, and duplicate pages MUST

Pages can be added at any position, removed, or copied. Deletion is confirmed per GL-07.

Done when: each operation works from the page sidebar and from the menu, and is fully undoable.

DOC-05 Reorder pages MUST

Page order changes by dragging in the sidebar and by "Move up" and "Move down" buttons, satisfying GL-04.

Done when: pages are successfully reordered using only the buttons.

DOC-06 Page sidebar MUST

A permanently visible sidebar shows every page as a numbered picture. Clicking one moves to it. The current page is marked by more than colour alone.

Done when: a 24-page magazine scrolls smoothly and every picture reflects current content within two seconds of a change.

DOC-07 Two pages side by side MUST

Interior pages display as facing pairs, as they appear in the finished magazine. Front and back cover display singly. A toggle switches to one page at a time.

Done when: a 12-page magazine displays as cover, five pairs, and back cover.

DOC-08 Zoom and fit MUST

The page can be magnified and reduced by clearly labelled buttons and a percentage, plus a "Fit to screen" control. Zoom level persists between sessions.

Done when: a user with reduced vision magnifies the page to 200% and edits text comfortably at that level.

D0C-09 Automatic page numbers SHOULD

Page numbers can be switched on for the whole magazine with a choice of position, renumbering automatically as pages change.

Done when: inserting a page at position 3 of 10 correctly renumbers all following pages.

D0C-10 Repeating background SHOULD

Items appearing on every page — a header, footer, or border — are set up once and applied throughout. Any page may opt out.

Done when: changing a repeating item updates every page using it, and opted-out pages are unaffected.

D0C-11 Rename and duplicate a magazine MUST

A magazine can be renamed at any time and copied whole, so this month's issue starts from last month's.

Done when: a duplicate opens with all content intact and no shared state with the original.

5.2 Text TXT**TXT-01 Add text** MUST

A clearly labelled "Add text" button places a text box on the page ready for typing. The user is never required to know they must draw a box first.

Done when: a first-time user adds text and types into it within 30 seconds, unaided.

TXT-02 Edit text in place MUST

A single click on existing text places a cursor. Text is typed, selected, and corrected exactly as in a word processor, including paste from other programs.

Done when: text pasted from a word processor and from a web page arrives with sensible formatting and no broken characters.

TXT-03 Font choice MUST

A large curated library of fonts, licensed for use and download, presented as a list where each name is shown *in that font* at a readable size. Recently used fonts appear at the top. Users do not upload their own fonts.

Done when: the list renders every font in its own face, scrolls smoothly, and applies the selection immediately.

TXT-04 Text size MUST

Size is set by choosing from common sizes, by typing an exact number, or by labelled larger and smaller buttons.

Done when: all three methods produce identical results for the same value.

TXT-05 Text colour MUST

Colour is chosen using the standard chooser (CLR-01) and applies to a selected range of characters as well as to a whole text box.

Done when: a single word within a paragraph is coloured differently from its neighbours.

TXT-06 Bold, italic, underline MUST

Three clearly labelled buttons showing their current state by more than colour alone.

Done when: each applies to a selected range and the button state reflects the selection accurately.

TXT-07 Alignment MUST

Left, centred, right, and "straight edges both sides" as labelled buttons, applied per paragraph.

Done when: all four apply correctly and justified text breaks without rivers at body size.

TXT-08 Line and letter spacing SHOULD

Two sliders, plainly labelled, each with a description and a reset to default.

Done when: both adjust visibly and reset returns to the exact original value.

TXT-09 Bullets and numbered lists SHOULD

Two buttons convert selected paragraphs to a bulleted or numbered list with correct indentation and hanging alignment.

Done when: lists render correctly in the downloaded PDF, including multi-line items.

TXT-10 Turn text to any angle MUST

Text can sit at any angle, not only horizontal — by a turn handle and by typing degrees, per GL-04.

Done when: text at 37 degrees renders identically on screen and in the PDF, and stays editable in place.

TXT-11 Text continues in another box MUST

When text does not fit, the user connects the box to another — on the same page or a later one — and text continues into it automatically. Editing earlier text reflows everything after it.

Done when: a 3,000-word article flows across six connected boxes and adding a sentence at the start correctly reflows all six.

TXT-12 Hidden text warning MUST

When text does not fit and is not continued elsewhere, an unmissable warning appears on the box, saying some text is hidden and offering to fix it.

Done when: the warning appears within one second of overflow and cannot be missed at a glance.

TXT-13 Saved looks MUST

Named looks such as "Heading" and "Body text" apply with one click. Changing a saved look updates every piece of text using it throughout the magazine.

Done when: changing the size of "Body text" updates all pages and the user is told how many items changed.

TXT-14 Spell check SHOULD

Misspellings are marked as the user types, with corrections on click and a personal dictionary.

Done when: marks never appear in downloaded output and do not interfere with selection.

5.3 Photographs IMG**IMG-01 Add a photo from the computer** MUST

Two routes, both prominent: a large "Add photo" button opening the file picker, and dragging a file from the desktop onto the page. Per GL-04 the button alone is sufficient.

Done when: a first-time user adds their own photo within 60 seconds, unaided.

IMG-02 Search the photo library MUST

A built-in library of licensed photographs, searched in plain language, with results shown as large previews. Selecting one places it on the page.

Done when: a search returns relevant results within three seconds and a chosen photo is placed at full usable quality.

IMG-03 Sensible placement on arrival MUST

A newly added photo appears at a reasonable size and position — never filling the whole page, never microscopic, never off-screen.

Done when: photos of ten widely differing shapes all arrive well placed and fully visible.

IMG-04 Remove a photo MUST

A selected photo is removed by a labelled button and by the Delete key. Removal is undoable.

Done when: removal works by both routes and undo restores the photo with its exact position and trim.

IMG-05 Trim a photo MUST

Part of a photo can be cut away, with a clear preview of what is kept and what is removed, and a single control restoring the whole image.

Done when: trimming is reversible at any later time without loss of the original.

IMG-06 Turn and flip MUST

Photos turn in quarter steps by button, to any angle by typed value, straighten by a small amount using a slider, and mirror horizontally or vertically.

Done when: all four combine correctly and match the downloaded output.

IMG-07 Replace a photo SHOULD

A photo can be swapped for another while keeping its position, size, and trim.

Done when: replacing a trimmed photo preserves the frame and applies a sensible equivalent trim.

IMG-08 Rounded corners SHOULD

Photo corners round by a slider, including fully circular.

Done when: rounding renders identically on screen and in downloaded output.

IMG-09 See-through SHOULD

Any item can be made partly see-through by a labelled slider from solid to invisible.

Done when: the effect matches between screen and downloaded output.

IMG-10 Text flows around a photo SHOULD

Text can flow around a photo rather than beneath it, with an adjustable gap. Version 1 flows around the photo's rectangle, not the shape of its subject.

Done when: flowing text avoids the photo correctly across a connected chain of boxes (TXT-11).

IMG-11 Photo quality warning SHOULD

If a photo is too low in quality to look good at its current size, a plain-language note appears on it suggesting making it smaller or using a larger photo.

Done when: the note appears and disappears correctly as the photo is resized past the threshold.

IMG-12 Adjustments, filters, background removal LATER

Brightness and contrast, filters, and automatic background removal.

Done when: deferred beyond version 1.

5.4 Shapes and lines SHP**SHP-01 Basic shapes** MUST

Rectangle, circle, and straight line, each added by one labelled button.

Done when: each is added, moved, resized, and coloured, and matches downloaded output.

SHP-02 Colour inside and outline MUST

Every shape has a colour inside and an outline with adjustable colour and thickness. Either can be switched off.

Done when: a shape with no colour inside and a thick outline downloads correctly.

SHP-03 Rounded corners on shapes SHOULD

Rectangle corners round by a slider.

Done when: rounding matches between screen and downloaded output.

SHP-04 Arrows, icons, shadows LATER

Arrow shapes, an icon library, and drop shadows.

Done when: deferred beyond version 1.

5.5 Arranging things ARR**ARR-01 Select an item** MUST

A single click selects. The selected item shows a clearly visible outline and handles of at least 14 pixels. Clicking empty space deselects.

Done when: the selection outline is visible against white, black, and busy photographic backgrounds.

ARR-02 Hover feedback MUST

Moving the pointer over an item highlights its outline, and the cursor changes to indicate what a click or drag would do — move, resize, turn, or edit text. Over a handle, the handle becomes more prominent. This is feedback only; per GL-03 no control is revealed by hovering.

Done when: every interactive area shows distinct hover feedback, and disabling hover entirely leaves all functions reachable.

ARR-03 Select several items MUST

Multiple items are selected by holding a modifier and clicking, by dragging a rectangle around them, and by "Select everything on this page". Per GL-04 the non-drag routes are sufficient alone.

Done when: multi-selection is achieved without any drag.

ARR-04 Move an item MUST

By dragging; by arrow keys moving a small step, or a large step with a modifier held; and by typing exact position values.

Done when: all three produce identical results and each is fully undoable.

ARR-05 Resize and reshape **MUST**

Corner and edge handles resize and reshape an item. Exact width and height can be typed. Photographs keep their proportions unless the user explicitly unlocks them.

Done when: a photo cannot be accidentally stretched out of proportion by a corner handle, and edge handles reshape text boxes correctly with text reflowing.

ARR-06 Turn to any angle **MUST**

By a turn handle and by typing degrees. Holding a modifier snaps to regular steps.

Done when: both methods agree and the result matches downloaded output.

ARR-07 Lining-up guides **MUST**

While an item is being moved or resized, guides appear showing alignment with page edges, margins, and other items, and the item snaps gently to them. Guides disappear when the movement ends.

Done when: guides appear for edges, centres, and equal spacing between three or more items.

ARR-08 Line up several items **MUST**

Buttons align selected items left, centre, right, top, middle, or bottom.

Done when: each of the six works correctly on a selection of mixed item types.

ARR-09 Space items evenly **SHOULD**

Buttons distribute three or more selected items evenly, horizontally or vertically.

Done when: gaps are equal to within one unit.

ARR-10 Bring to front, send to back **MUST**

Four labelled buttons: bring to front, bring forward, send backward, send to back.

Done when: stacking changes correctly and matches downloaded output.

ARR-11 Lock an item **MUST**

An item can be locked so it cannot be moved or changed by accident, showing a clear marker, unlocked by an obvious button.

Done when: a locked item resists move, resize, and delete, and the user is told why.

ARR-12 Copy, paste, duplicate, delete **MUST**

All four as labelled buttons and standard keyboard shortcuts. Pasted items appear slightly offset so they are visible.

Done when: items copy correctly between pages and between magazines.

ARR-13 Group items **SHOULD**

Several items can be joined so they move and resize together, and separated again.

Done when: grouping and ungrouping preserve exact positions and sizes.

ARR-14 Copy the look of an item **SHOULD**

A "Copy look" button applies one item's formatting to another.

Done when: formatting transfers between two text boxes and between two shapes.

5.6 Colour CLR

CLR-01 One colour chooser everywhere **MUST**

A single chooser used throughout, showing in order: the magazine's palette, recently used colours, standard colours, and a full picker behind "More colours".

Done when: the identical chooser appears for text, shape colour, outline, and page background.

CLR-02 Magazine palette **MUST**

A small set of colours saved with the magazine and offered first everywhere, so a consistent look happens without effort.

Done when: palette colours persist across sessions and appear first in every chooser.

CLR-03 Recently used colours **MUST**

The last eight colours used are always available.

Done when: the list updates immediately and survives a reload.

CLR-04 Page background colour **MUST**

Any page can be given a background colour, applied to one page or to all.

Done when: background colour matches between screen and downloaded output.

CLR-05 Pick a colour from a photo **SHOULD**

A tool picks any colour from a photograph on the page, so text can be matched to an image.

Done when: the picked colour matches the source exactly.

5.7 Publishing and versions PUB

PUB-01 Publish **MUST**

One prominent Publish action freezes the magazine as it stands, numbers it as the next version, and produces the shareable link, the PDF, and the page pictures. The user is told plainly what was produced and where to find it.

Done when: a first-time user publishes successfully and locates the resulting link, unaided.

PUB-02 Published versions never change **MUST**

Editing after publishing changes only the working copy. A published version is frozen permanently and is never altered by later edits.

Done when: a magazine is published, then edited heavily, and the published link and PDF are byte-identical to before the edits.

PUB-03 Version list **MUST**

A simple list of published versions with their numbers and dates, each offering its link and its downloads.

Done when: a magazine published three times shows three versions, each opening its own correct output.

PUB-04 Shareable link **MUST**

Each published version has a link anyone can open in a browser to read the magazine, without an account and without the editing interface. It works on phones and tablets.

Done when: the link opens correctly on a phone, a tablet, and a desktop browser for someone with no account.

PUB-05 Download as PDF **MUST**

Each published version downloads as a PDF suitable for emailing and for home printing, with text remaining selectable.

Done when: a 24-page magazine produces a file small enough to email comfortably, and prints correctly on a home printer.

PUB-06 Download pages as pictures **SHOULD**

Individual pages save as image files for use on a website or social media.

Done when: exported images match the on-screen appearance exactly.

PUB-07 Checks before publishing **MUST**

Before publishing, the product checks for hidden text, very low-quality photos, and items falling off the page, and reports problems in plain words with a way to jump straight to each. The user may publish anyway.

Done when: each problem type is detected reliably and clicking it navigates to the affected item.

PUB-08 Go back to an earlier version **SHOULD**

A published version can be copied back over the working copy, so a user who has made a mess can return to a known good state. Confirmed per GL-07.

Done when: restoring version 1 over a heavily edited working copy produces content identical to version 1, and version 2 remains untouched.

5.8 Help **HLP****HLP-01 Reopenable guided tour** **MUST**

A short walkthrough of the main functions, available at any time from a permanently visible Help button — never a one-time overlay that cannot be recovered.

Done when: the tour can be started, left, and restarted from any point.

HLP-02 Help on every panel **MUST**

Every panel has a help control explaining its controls in plain words, with a picture where useful.

Done when: every panel has help text reviewed against Section 9.

HLP-03 Interface text size setting **MUST**

A prominent setting makes all interface text larger, up to the GL-02 maximum. Offered on first use, not buried in preferences.

Done when: a first-time user finds it unaided and it persists between sessions.

6. Deliberately excluded from version 1

Each item below is useful and each is excluded on purpose. Every feature is surface area for defects, and the current platform's central failure is unreliability. A small product that works flawlessly beats a large one that mostly works.

EXCLUDED	REASON
All AI features	Deferred to the next release by decision. See Section 7 for what version 1 must not preclude.
Commercial print output	Screen-first by decision. No professional colour handling, extra edges, or print-shop checks.
Uploading your own fonts	Licence checking and legal exposure. A large curated library covers the need.
Background removal	Substantial cost, unpredictable results, not needed to make a magazine.
Photo filters and adjustments	Large surface area, high defect risk, marginal benefit.
Curved and shaped text	Significant complexity for a decorative effect.
Drop shadows and effects	Complicates output, particularly see-through handling.
Icon and illustration library	Licensing and curation cost. Users have photographs and shapes.
Text flowing around a subject's outline	Rectangle flow only (IMG-10). Contour flow is much harder for a small visual gain.
Two people editing at once	The single largest source of engineering risk. Our user works alone.
Comments and suggestions	Depends on simultaneous editing.
Editing on a phone	Reading on a phone is required (PUB-04). Editing on a small screen conflicts with every principle in Section 3.
Languages other than English	Version 1 is English only. Adding a language means re-authoring Section 9, not translating it.

7. What version 1 must not preclude

The next release adds AI: generating a magazine from a description, editing it by asking in plain words, and speaking to it rather than typing. None of that is built now. But version 1 makes decisions that either enable it cheaply or force a rewrite, so these constraints apply from the first line of code.

FWD-01 One route for every change **MUST**

Every change to a magazine happens through a single named, validated instruction that carries its own reverse. Nothing anywhere modifies a magazine by any other route.

Done when: an audit confirms no code path changes a magazine except through this layer, and every instruction has a working reverse.

FWD-02 The AI will use the same instructions **MUST**

The set of instructions is complete enough that everything a user can do by hand is expressible as one. When the AI is added, it will issue these same instructions — so anything not expressible this way will be impossible for the AI to do.

Done when: every requirement in Section 5 is achievable purely by issuing instructions, with no interface interaction.

FWD-03 Undo does not care who acted **MUST**

The undo history records instructions, not who or what issued them. An AI-made change and a hand-made change are undone identically, by the same button.

Done when: instructions issued programmatically appear in the undo history and reverse correctly.

FWD-04 Everything has a stable name **MUST**

Every page and every item on it has a permanent identifier that survives editing, saving, and reloading, so a later instruction can refer to a specific thing unambiguously.

Done when: an identifier captured at the start of a session still refers to the same item after 100 edits and a reload.

FWD-05 The magazine is fully described by its data **MUST**

Everything about a magazine's appearance lives in its stored data. No aspect of it exists only inside an interface component or a browser's memory.

Done when: a magazine rendered on a server, with no browser involved, is visually identical to the same magazine on screen.

FWD-06 Ready-made designs are data, not code **MUST**

The ready-made designs in DOC-02 are described as data, so more can be added later without programming — which is how the AI will later choose layouts.

Done when: a new ready-made design is added without changing any application code.

FWD-07 What is selected is knowable **MUST**

What the user currently has selected is available as data. Later, this is how the AI resolves "make *this* bigger" without asking.

Done when: current selection is readable at any moment and correctly reflects the interface.

8. Quality bar and parallel work

The plan is to build with several workstreams running at once, each owning a small area. That produces reliable software only if the boundaries are explicit. This section defines them.

8.1 Definition of done

A requirement is complete only when every line below is true. A requirement failing any of them is not ready to merge.

1. The **Done when** criterion is demonstrated, not asserted.
2. An automated test covers it and runs in the build pipeline.
3. The feature is fully undoable and redoable.
4. It works by keyboard alone.
5. It works without any drag.
6. It changes the magazine only through the instruction layer (FWD-01).
7. All user-facing text passes the Section 9 scan.
8. Every control meets GL-01 and GL-02.
9. It works at 200% browser zoom.
10. Every error path shows a plain-language message with a next step.
11. Someone outside the team has used it to complete a real task.

8.2 Ownership boundaries

SURFACE	OWNERSHIP	RULE
Magazine data structure	Single owner	Changes proposed, reviewed, and merged one at a time. Never edited by two workstreams concurrently.
Instruction set	Single owner	A workstream may <i>add</i> instructions freely. Changing an existing one requires coordination.
Toolbar shell	Single owner	Positions are fixed by GL-09. Features fill slots; they do not restructure it.
Page drawing	Single owner	Features add item types; they do not alter how the page is drawn.
Feature panels	Feature owner	Each feature owns its panel outright.
Vocabulary list	Single owner	Additions proposed centrally so terminology stays consistent.

8.3 Rules for parallel workstreams

- A workstream owns whole requirement IDs, never parts of one.
- No workstream modifies another's panel or instructions. Changes there are requested, not made.
- Adding to a shared surface is allowed; changing existing behaviour on one is not, without coordination.
- Every workstream runs the full Section 4 check before merging, not only its own tests.
- The primary acceptance test runs against every merge to the main branch. If it breaks, the merge is reverted rather than patched forward.
- Requirements marked LATER are not started, not scaffolded, and not designed for.

ON BUILDING WITHOUT BUGS

Reliability comes from small scope and sharp acceptance criteria, not from effort or from the number of parallel workstreams. Adding capacity to an under-specified requirement produces *more* defects, because each workstream fills the gaps differently and the seams between them are where bugs live.

The highest-leverage work available before building is therefore making every **Done when** line sharp enough that two independent workstreams reading it would build the same thing.

9. Approved vocabulary

The only permitted terms in user-facing text. The left column must not appear anywhere the user can see it. Enforced by automated scan (GL-08).

NEVER SAY	SAY INSTEAD
Opacity, alpha, transparency	See-through
Kerning, tracking	Letter spacing
Leading, line height	Line spacing
Z-index, layer order, stacking	Bring to front / Send to back
Crop	Trim
Stroke	Outline
Fill	Colour inside
Justify, justified	Straight edges both sides
Thread, flow, link frames	Continue in another box
Overflow, overset	Some text is hidden
Master page, parent page	Repeating background

Baseline grid, snapping	Lining-up guides
Export, render, generate	Download / Publish
Canvas, artboard	Page
Element, object, asset, node	Item / Photo / Text / Shape
Font family, typeface, glyph	Font
Spread	Two pages side by side
Style sheet, paragraph style	Saved look
Rotate, transform	Turn
Aspect ratio, constrain proportions	Keep the shape
Template, master	Ready-made design
Document	Magazine
Revision, commit, snapshot	Version
Resolution, DPI, PPI	Photo quality
Undo history, transaction	Undo

10. Validating with real users

Nothing here is worth anything until tested with the people it is for. Internal review consistently fails to catch what matters, because everyone on the team already knows how the product works. The current platform's failures are evidence enough.

10.1 Schedule

WHEN	WHAT
Before building	Clickable prototype tested with five people aged 70+. Confirms layout and vocabulary before code is written.
After each area	One session per completed area, testing that area's tasks.
Before release	Full primary acceptance test with five fresh participants who have never seen the product.
One week later	The same participants make a second issue, confirming the tool is memorable and not merely learnable.
Existing users	At least three current users of the old platform test the replacement and compare directly.

10.2 How to run a session

- Give a real goal — "make a two-page magazine about your garden club" — not a list of steps.
- Do not help, hint, or explain. Where they get stuck is the entire finding.
- Record where they hesitate, what they click that does nothing, and what words they use for things.
- Any term a participant does not recognise is added to Section 9 as forbidden.
- Three or more participants failing the same step makes it a defect, not a training problem.

11. Decisions still open

#	QUESTION	WHY IT MATTERS
1	Who designs the ready-made designs?	DOC-02 requires at least twelve at launch, and the AI phase later needs far more. This is a design commission with a long lead time, on the critical path, and the single biggest factor in whether output looks modern. It needs an owner now.
2	Who recruits and runs the user sessions?	Finding five participants aged 70+ takes weeks. Without an owner this silently never happens, and usability problems surface after launch — exactly how the current platform got into difficulty.
3	Do existing users and their magazines migrate?	If current users must be carried over, their existing magazines need importing, which is a substantial piece of work not costed anywhere in this document.
4	Is a shared link public or private?	PUB-04 assumes anyone with the link can read it. If magazines can be private or password-protected, that changes the publishing work.

NEXT STEP

Settle open decision 1, then break Section 5 into individual work items — one per requirement ID — and confirm each line is precise enough that two independent workstreams would build the same thing from it.